Learn About Care Arrangements for Your Mother While Nothing Is Urgent

Four prompts to write down what your mother wants, sort what you actually know about the kinds of care, mark what would have to be confirmed later, and decide what would send you back to look harder.

Where you are

Your mother is doing fine. You've watched friends scramble when a parent's situation changed, and you'd rather understand the landscape now than learn it in a hospital hallway. Nobody is moving anywhere.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can name the kinds of arrangements your family wants to understand, say what your mother has told you she wants, and describe what would need to be true before any of it became a real question.

A one-page Future Options Notes sheet: What my mother wants, What we know and want to learn about each kind of arrangement, What we'd have to confirm later, and What would bring us back to this.

Before you start

- Anything your mother has said about where and how she wants to live as she gets older.
- What you've picked up about different kinds of care from friends, relatives, or the news, however secondhand.
- A rough idea of who in the family would be nearby and involved. Scraps are fine; this is a starting point, not a file.

PROMPT 1

Write down what your mother has actually said

WHY THIS MATTERS

Families carry strong beliefs about what a parent wants, often from one conversation years ago. Before learning about options, it helps to separate what she has said from what you've assumed.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your memory of things your mother has said about her future, and anything she's written.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything I can remember my mother saying about where and how she wants to live as she gets older, plus what the rest of us tend to assume:

> [PASTE WHAT SHE HAS SAID AND WHAT YOU ASSUME]
>
> Sort it into three lists: WHAT SHE HAS SAID, in her words where I've given them; WHAT WE ASSUME BUT SHE HASN'T SAID; and WHAT WE'VE NEVER ASKED HER. For the third list, draft each item as a gentle question I could ask her over coffee, not in a meeting. Don't guess at her answers.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How short the first list is compared with the second. That gap is the point.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask her one question from the third list this week, and write down what she says.

PROMPT 2

Sort what you think you know about the kinds of care

WHY THIS MATTERS

Most of what we know about assisted living, home care, or a nursing home comes from a friend's experience or a commercial. Some of it is right. Writing it down shows where your picture is thin.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your own impressions of the different kinds of care, including the ones you're unsure about.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what my family thinks we know about the different kinds of care arrangements, from help at home to residential settings:
>
> [PASTE YOUR IMPRESSIONS]
>
> Make a table with one row per kind of arrangement I mentioned and three columns: WHAT WE THINK WE KNOW, WHERE THAT CAME FROM (a friend, an ad, a visit, not sure), and WHAT WE'D WANT TO LEARN. If I've lumped two different things under one name, say so. Do not fill in the facts yourself, judge which arrangement suits my mother, or mention any specific place or company. We are learning, not choosing.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Rows where everything you know came from one source.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Pick the one arrangement you understand least and put it first on your learning list.

PROMPT 3

Mark what could only be confirmed later

WHY THIS MATTERS

Anything you learn now about availability, cost, or what a setting can handle will be out of date by the time it matters. Knowing which facts expire keeps you from building a plan on them.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The table from Prompt 2.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is my family's table of what we know and want to learn about care arrangements for my mother:
>
> [PASTE THE TABLE FROM PROMPT 2]
>
> Go through each item and mark it in one of three ways: STABLE (unlikely to change, worth learning now), EXPIRES (would need checking again close to the time, such as availability, prices, staffing, or what a setting accepts), or DEPENDS ON HER NEEDS (can't be judged until we know what she actually requires). Then list the DEPENDS ON HER NEEDS items as questions we would bring to a care consultant later. Do not estimate costs, predict her needs, or recommend an arrangement.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How much of the list sits in the last two groups. That's what stays open on purpose.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Put a date in your calendar, six or twelve months out, to reread the list.

PROMPT 4

Write the page you'll come back to

WHY THIS MATTERS

This isn't a decision, so the page shouldn't look like one. It should hold your mother's wishes, what you've learned, what's still open, and the signals that would tell you to come back and look harder.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from Prompts 1 to 3.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what my family has gathered about future care arrangements for my mother:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Write one page with four headings: WHAT MY MOTHER WANTS, WHAT WE KNOW AND WANT TO LEARN ABOUT EACH KIND OF ARRANGEMENT, WHAT WE'D HAVE TO CONFIRM LATER, and WHAT WOULD BRING US BACK TO THIS PAGE. For the last heading, list observable changes in her health, home, or support that would make a closer look sensible, written as things to notice, not as warnings. Do not recommend or compare settings, name any provider, or say anything about her safety.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page you'd be comfortable showing your mother.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Show it to her, and to the siblings who weren't in the room.

Give the options something to be measured against

Learning about care arrangements is more useful once your mother's current situation is written down. The care interview organizes it into a Family Care Profile, and that profile is the file you and your care consultant will revisit as her needs change.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›